



It is difficult for a person to master all core areas in Linux. The best option is to choose a career path in Linux and then specialise in it"

R Krishnan
Executive Director
Aptech

systems, servers, and other hardware serves as an add-on.

Education And Certifications

In the case of Linux, very few people—referred to as self-proclaimed geeks—would have landed decent jobs without formal Linux education, training, or qualification.

"Most organisations prefer to hire experienced candidates. For example, Linux certification is a must for system administrators, and for developers, a good programming background is required," informs R Krishnan, Executive director at Aptech, who provide computer courseware, IT education, and training.

It is today advisable to choose courses offered by Linux OS vendors—Red Hat or Novell—and select certifications modules in accordance with your area of interest. You could go the self-learning way, using the freely-available Linux OSes, but bear in mind that certification is always preferred.

"Students from engineering backgrounds with an exposure to working on Linux are considered the perfect fit. It's a proven hypothesis that students from mathematics and statistics backgrounds make good programmers," avers Raj Ganti, CEO, SQL Star International, who are involved in providing high-end IT training to aspiring and practising IT professionals as well as corporate executives.

Vendors such as Red Hat and Novell, who offer their Linux OSes for enterprises, have certification courses for individuals as well as professionals. Visit the vendors' Web sites for detailed information about the certifications offered:

Red Hat India: www.redhat.in/training/

Novell India: www.novell.com/training/

IBM: www-03.ibm.com/linux/va_3261.shtml

Sun: www.sun.com/training/catalog/operating_systems/index.xml

Oracle: www.oracle.com/global/us/education/linux/training.html

Turbolinux: www.turbolinux.co.in/solution_service/training.html

Courses are offered at three levels—Certified Technician (Beginner), Professional (Intermediate), and Administrator / Engineer (Advanced). Structured programmes are available through training partners. Courses by these vendors do cover cross-platform environments.

The learning process doesn't stop after acquiring the necessary certification. "Well-structured programmes help in getting the basics right, which are very important in any case. But the fact is that 80 per cent of application and learning happens on the job. One has to attend to problems and client queries, and to troubleshoot, efficiently, which is possible through constant learning and its practice through implementation," says Jeet Patel, who works as Tech Support Analyst (Linux) with a multinational company.

The Employer's Expectations

Initial training includes induction and exposure to the workflow of the company. As required, organisations prefer Linux profession-

als to attend to and give exams for the structured programmes offered by the principal vendors—Red Hat, Novell, Oracle, Sun, and IBM.

"Employee training programmes are very important to keep the Linux professional updated, and in the long run, to meet client requirements. The initial training is imparted for period of three to six months, based on the domains in which they work. Corporate training sessions and classroom training programmes are organised for skill-enhancement of the candidates in their domain," says Saravanan.

Vendor companies like Oracle and SAP for database packages, Sun for server networking and security, and Sun for Java offer structured programmes for those interested in working on Linux in a particular area. A certificate of attendance, besides the certification of passing, is indeed offered by these organisations.

"Holding a certificate of having attended a structured programme—and a certification of passing—adds value to a candidate's profile. Also, it makes it easier for an employer to short-list candidates," says Ganti.

Despite the fact that the demand/supply gap for Linux professionals is very high, certain unsaid rules for enthusiasts prevail. The most important and basic rule is, don't take up Linux as an option just to make money. A passion for constant learning is extremely important. Do not get blinkered by billion-dollar figures of future opportunities. It's therefore a crucial decision at the outset; always think about learning and growth, otherwise you might just end up with a monotonous job with negligible future prospects.

A Few Parting Words

Various activities now rely on Linux. Recently, Dell started selling Desktops and laptops with the Ubuntu flavour of Linux pre-loaded. Research firm IDC (International Data Corporation) estimates that the Indian Linux market will grow at the rate of 21% annually, to Rs 91.5 crore in 2010, mostly for services. Server shipments rose by 15.3% globally in the fourth quarter of 2006. The server space is responsible for the biggest pool of opportunities today.

According to a forecast by ABI Research, commercial Linux OSes will be enabled on more than 1.3 crore mobile devices globally by 2012, up from 81 lakh in 2007.

These figures indicate future requirements, but the reality is that an average Linux aspirant could face stagnation in his or her career graph after reaching the middle level. This could be combated by constant learning and upgradation of one's skill-sets.

Expertise in Windows can be gained by classroom learning, while in the case of Linux, remember what experience has taught Patel: "The fact is that 80 per cent of application and learning happens on the job."

And so, at the end, geekiness is just the beginning; if you want to make a career of a passion, learning should never stop. ■

samir_makwana@thinkdigit.com